Simple Business English

How to Give Feedback When an Employee Misses a Deadline | Business English

Situation: Nadia, Head of Sales at an FMCG supplier, invites Julian into her office for a one-on-one meeting. Julian has missed his monthly sales reporting deadline for the second consecutive month, delaying Nadia's consolidated report to the board.
Nadia — Head of Sales at an FMCG company · **Julian** — Key Account Manager handling retail supermarket chains

Transcript

Nadia: Come on in, Julian. Please have a seat.
Julian: Thanks, Nadia. How are things going with you today?
Nadia: Busy as always, but good. How was your trip to the northern region?
Julian: It was very productive. We closed two major retail orders with HyperMart.
Nadia: That is great to hear. Your work with HyperMart has been really impressive this quarter.
Julian: Thank you. The store managers were tough, but we reached a solid agreement.
Nadia: I wanted to talk to you about our monthly reporting process today.
Julian: Sure. Is there something missing in my latest submission?
Nadia: No, the data itself is accurate and detailed. The issue is the timing.
Julian: Ah, you mean the monthly sales report from last week.
Nadia: Yes. **The deadline was** the second of the month, at five in the afternoon.
Julian: Right. I remember that was the official date on the schedule.
Nadia: We received your file on the sixth, four days after the deadline.
Julian: Yes, I apologize for that delay. It was a crazy week.
Nadia: The same thing happened last month too. Your report arrived on the fifth.
Julian: I know, Nadia. I really wanted to submit it on time this time.
Nadia: Help me understand what happened. What caused the delay this month?
Julian: Honestly, **I was overwhelmed with** store visits during the final three days.
Nadia: Which clients required your attention at that exact moment?
Julian: Both MegaStore and CityMarket had urgent shelf-space issues before their weekend promotions.
Nadia: Did you have to visit all those stores in person?
Julian: Yes, their regional managers insisted on inspecting the displays before signing off.
Nadia: I see. That sounds like a heavy workload at the end of the month.
Julian: It really was. By the time I returned home, I was completely exhausted.
Nadia: I understand that client emergencies happen, Julian. But we need to look at the results.
Julian: But in the end, we secured the promotional space and protected our volume.
Nadia: Yes, and that is a positive result for your accounts.
Julian: So I thought that client revenue was our top priority.
Nadia: It is a priority, but reporting is not an optional task.
Julian: I know it is required, but I viewed it as internal paperwork.
Nadia: The impact of this is bigger than just paperwork, Julian.
Julian: Could you explain how it affects the wider department?
Nadia: I must combine all regional numbers into one consolidated report for the board.
Julian: And my missing figures hold back the entire document.
Nadia: Exactly. Without your sales figures, our total revenue number is incomplete.

Julian: I see. I did not realize you could not submit the others first.
Nadia: The finance director requires the full company overview by the fourth of each month.
Julian: So because I was late, you were late with your own report.
Nadia: Yes, I had to ask the executive board for an extension two months in a row.
Julian: That sounds very uncomfortable. I am really sorry about putting you in that position.
Nadia: Thank you, Julian. It also damages our department's reputation for reliability.
Julian: I definitely do not want our team to look bad in front of senior management.
Nadia: I know you don't. That is why we are having this open conversation today.
Julian: I appreciate you telling me directly instead of sending an angry email.
Nadia: Direct communication is always better. And **I value your work on** key accounts very highly.
Julian: Thank you, Nadia. I care a lot about my clients and our sales targets.
Nadia: Your sales grew by fourteen percent this quarter, which is the highest in the team.
Julian: We worked very hard with our distributors to achieve that growth.
Nadia: Your relationship management is fantastic. Clients trust you, and that brings real value.
Julian: That means a lot to hear, especially when we face tough negotiations.
Nadia: That is why I want to solve this reporting issue without hurting your sales performance.
Julian: I agree. I want to find a sustainable way to handle both responsibilities.
Nadia: How can we avoid this in the future?
Julian: I need to change how I collect the sales numbers during the month.
Nadia: Tell me more about that. How do you collect them right now?
Julian: I wait until the last day of the month to download all invoice data.
Nadia: And then you verify every single order manually in one evening.
Julian: Exactly. It usually takes me five or six hours without interruptions.
Nadia: That is too much work to leave for the final twenty-four hours.
Julian: What if I start updating the spreadsheet earlier in the month?
Nadia: That sounds sensible. How early could you prepare a working draft?
Julian: I could export eighty percent of the volume data around the twenty-fifth.
Nadia: That would give you plenty of time before the final month-end rush.
Julian: Yes. Then on the twenty-eighth, I can prepare a solid preliminary draft.
Nadia: What remaining numbers would you need to enter after the twenty-eighth?
Julian: Just the final three days of retail shipments and pending returns.
Nadia: That sounds manageable. How much time would that final update take?
Julian: Probably less than an hour on the morning of the second.
Nadia: That would allow you to deliver the completed report before noon.
Julian: Yes, easily. That gives me a comfortable buffer before the five o'clock deadline.
Nadia: Does this schedule work for you?
Julian: Yes, it spreads out the administrative work over two weeks instead of two days.
Nadia: What will you do if another client crisis happens on the first or second?
Julian: Because most numbers are already prepared, I can finish the file in forty minutes.
Nadia: And if an emergency still prevents you from sending it by noon?
Julian: I will call you immediately by ten in the morning to explain the situation.
Nadia: Perfect. Never leave me guessing whether a report is coming or not.
Julian: Understood. I should have alerted you earlier last week when I fell behind.
Nadia: Clear communication makes all the difference when deadlines are tight.
Julian: I will definitely communicate earlier if any unexpected issue appears.

Nadia: Let's set a reminder for the preliminary draft on your calendar right now.
Julian: Good idea. I am scheduling a reminder for the twenty-eighth at two in the afternoon.
Nadia: Excellent. That gives you three working days before the final submission.
Julian: I will block out two hours on my calendar for that draft review.
Nadia: Do you need any assistance from our data analyst to automate your exports?
Julian: Actually, a template that pulls figures from our CRM would save me two hours.
Nadia: I will ask Oliver from IT to share the automated template with you tomorrow.
Julian: That will make the entire process much faster and reduce manual errors.
Nadia: Let's check in again next month to see how the new system worked.
Julian: That sounds fair. When should we have that quick check-in?
Nadia: How about the seventh of next month, right after the reporting cycle closes?
Julian: That works perfectly. I will put a fifteen-minute meeting in your calendar.
Nadia: Great. I am confident you will handle this smoothly, Julian.
Julian: Thank you for your support and for being constructive about this, Nadia.
Nadia: We are a team, and we succeed when every part runs on time.
Julian: Absolutely. You will have my next report on the second before twelve noon.
Nadia: Wonderful. Good luck with the HyperMart promotional launch this Friday.
Julian: Thanks, Nadia. I will head back to my desk and set up those calendar blocks.

Key phrases from this episode

I wanted to talk to you about	a polite, direct way to introduce a meeting topic — I wanted to talk to you about our budget for next quarter. — I wanted to talk to you about the feedback from our supplier.
The deadline was	stating the agreed time limit clearly and factually — The deadline was Friday at noon, but the file arrived on Monday. — The deadline was yesterday, so we must submit the proposal right away.
Help me understand what happened.	asking for an explanation calmly without showing immediate anger — We missed the shipment date. Help me understand what happened. — The client rejected our proposal. Help me understand what happened.
I was overwhelmed with	having too much work to manage comfortably — I was overwhelmed with customer calls all morning. — The warehouse manager was overwhelmed with delivery requests yesterday.
The impact of this is	explaining the negative result or practical consequence of an issue — The impact of this is that production will stop for three days. — The impact of this is that our cash flow becomes very tight.
I value your work on	expressing genuine appreciation for someone's specific contribution — I value your work on this supermarket expansion project. — Our team values your work on improving client contracts.
How can we avoid this in the future?	inviting the other person to help solve a recurring problem — This stock shortage cost us money. How can we avoid this in the future? — How can we avoid this in the future when customer demand spikes?
Does this schedule work for you?	checking if proposed dates or times are practical for someone — We plan to deliver every Tuesday. Does this schedule work for you? — Does this schedule work for you, or do you need more preparation time?
Let's set a reminder for	agreeing to create a calendar notification to prevent delays — Let's set a reminder for next Thursday to review inventory levels. — Let's set a reminder for Monday morning before the client call.

Let's check in again next month	agreeing on a short review meeting after one month — Let's check in again next month to evaluate our sales progress. — Let's check in again next month to see if delivery delays stopped.

Common mistakes

✗ Not: ~~I was late with four days for the monthly sales report.~~
✓ Better: **I was late by four days for the monthly sales report.**
Use 'late by [time period]', not 'late with'.

✗ Not: ~~Julian is a very accurate manager who always arrives on time.~~
✓ Better: **Julian is a very punctual manager who always arrives on time.**
'Accurate' means error-free. To mean doing things on time, use 'punctual'.

✗ Not: ~~I apologize on the delay of my monthly sales report.~~
✓ Better: **I apologize for the delay of my monthly sales report.**
The verb 'apologize' requires 'for' an error, not 'on'.

✗ Not: ~~Could you explain me how this delay affects our team?~~
✓ Better: **Could you explain to me how this delay affects our team?**
The verb 'explain' requires 'to me', never directly 'explain me'.

✗ Not: ~~Nadia made feedback to Julian about the missing report.~~
✓ Better: **Nadia gave feedback to Julian about the missing report.**
Use the verb 'give' or 'provide' with feedback, not 'make'.

Quiz

1. Why did Nadia schedule a one-on-one meeting with Julian?
A) Julian missed his monthly reporting deadline twice.
B) Julian lost an important retail supermarket client.
C) Julian requested a salary increase and promotion.

2. What caused Julian's reporting delay this month?
A) He went on an unplanned vacation.
B) He handled urgent store visits for key clients.
C) His company laptop broke down completely.

3. How did Julian's late report affect Nadia's own work?
A) She was late delivering the consolidated report to executives.
B) She had to personally visit HyperMart stores.
C) She lost her quarterly bonus payment.

4. What new reporting routine do Nadia and Julian establish?
A) Julian stops doing client visits at month-end.
B) Julian will prepare a draft report by the twenty-eighth.
C) An IT specialist will write Julian's reports entirely.

5. What positive result does Nadia highlight about Julian's commercial work?
A) His account sales grew by fourteen percent this quarter.
B) He never complained about heavy company workloads.
C) He found five new distributors in the northern region.

Answers: 1-A 2-B 3-A 4-B 5-A

Dialogue voices are AI-generated. Every episode is built on a real, anonymized case from the host's 15+ years in FMCG and key account management.